

Free to Choose? Determinism, Libertarianism, and Compatibilism

An original lesson plan inspired by **Timothy O'Connor & Christopher Evan Franklin's** the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* entry on *Free Will*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* or *Timothy O'Connor & Christopher Evan Franklin*. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/freewill/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Metaphysics

“If every choice you make is the result of prior causes stretching back before you were born, can you ever really be said to choose freely — and does it matter whether the universe is deterministic?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the three major positions in the free will debate: hard determinism, libertarianism, and compatibilism.
- Apply the Consequence Argument and a Frankfurt-style case to test whether determinism and free will, or at least moral responsibility, are compatible.
- Evaluate whether moral responsibility requires libertarian free will or whether compatibilist freedom is sufficient, and defend a position with reference to at least one objection.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard for a three-column comparison chart (hard determinism / libertarianism / compatibilism)
- Handout describing a Frankfurt-style case (a neuroscientist who would force a choice but never needs to intervene because the agent chooses that way anyway)
- Dominoes or a marble run as a physical prop for modeling deterministic causal chains
- Index cards for an anonymous position poll

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Domino Chain

8 min

Set up and knock over a short line of dominoes. Ask whether the last domino's fall was "free" or entirely determined by the first push and the laws of physics, then ask students whether human choices are more like the dominoes, or different in kind, and why.

Direct Instruction: Three Positions

18 min

Present hard determinism (determinism is true and incompatible with free will, so we lack free will), libertarianism (we have a robust, undetermined kind of free will, which requires that determinism be false at least for free choices), and compatibilism (free will just means acting on your own desires and reasons without external coercion, which is compatible with determinism). Introduce Frankfurt's challenge to the assumption that free will requires being able to have done otherwise.

Small-Group Testing with Cases

18 min

Groups work through the Consequence Argument — if determinism is true, your acts are the consequences of the laws of nature and the distant past, neither of which is up to you, so your acts are not "up to you" either — and the Frankfurt case, where a would-be controller never needs to intervene because the agent freely chooses the desired option anyway. Each group decides which position handles both cases most consistently.

Whole-Class Debate

11 min

Groups share their findings. Press on whether compatibilism's redefinition of "free" is a genuine solution to the problem or, as some libertarians object, simply "changing the subject" to something less than what we ordinarily mean by freedom.

Closure

5 min

Anonymous index-card vote on final position with a one-sentence reason; reveal the tally to the class.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does the Consequence Argument show that free will is impossible under determinism, or is there a flaw in treating the laws of nature and the distant past as things "not up to us" in a way that transmits to our present actions?
- 2 Does the Frankfurt case succeed in showing that moral responsibility doesn't require the ability to have done otherwise, or does it smuggle in the very alternative possibilities it claims to eliminate?
- 3 Is compatibilism a genuine solution to the free will problem, or is it "changing the subject" by redefining freedom as something less than what we intuitively mean by the term?
- 4 If libertarian free will requires that some choices are not fully determined by prior causes, doesn't that risk making choices random or a matter of chance rather than "free" in any meaningful sense?
- 5 Does it matter, practically, which theory is true? Would discovering that hard determinism is correct change how we punish, praise, or hold each other responsible?

Assessment

Students write a position paper defending hard determinism, libertarianism, or compatibilism as the most defensible view, using the Consequence Argument and the Frankfurt case discussed in class as required evidence, and responding to at least one objection to their chosen position. Grade on accurate representation of



the arguments and consistency of the position defended, not on which view is chosen.

Extension Activity

Have students research a real legal or ethical debate that turns partly on assumptions about free will — such as debates over neuroscience and criminal sentencing, or addiction and moral responsibility — and write a short memo analyzing which of the three positions from class that debate implicitly assumes.

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